

The United Kingdom's Rwanda Policy: Migration Deterrence, Political Debate and Policy Challenges

Policy brief

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Executive Summary

This policy brief examines the United Kingdom's Rwanda Migration Partnership, a policy introduced in 2022 to deter illegal migration across the English Channel by relocating certain asylum seekers to Rwanda for processing. The analysis covers the policy's rationale, implementation challenges, early results, and criticisms from human rights organisations.

Key findings:

- The policy has shown some deterrent effects, including reduced crossings and secondary movement to Ireland.
- Human rights concerns regarding Rwanda's asylum system and the policy's compliance with international law remain unresolved.
- The long-term effectiveness and legality of the policy are still uncertain, with ongoing legal challenges and limited implementation.

Recommendation: While the policy has introduced a new model for migration deterrence, its ethical and legal viability remains questionable. European policymakers should monitor the scheme's outcomes carefully before considering similar approaches.

1. Background

The UK-Rwanda Migration Partnership was announced in April 2022. Under the agreement, individuals who entered the UK illegally after 1 January 2022 may be relocated to Rwanda, where their asylum claims will be processed. Those granted refugee status will remain in Rwanda; those denied may seek protection elsewhere, but they cannot return to the UK (BBC, 2024).

Rwanda receives financial compensation from the UK government. By 2023, Rwanda had received £240 million, with additional payments scheduled through 2027 (National Audit Office, 2024). The Rwandan government has reported using these funds for education, infrastructure, job creation, and health services (National Audit Office, 2024).

Rwanda has reportedly prepared reception and accommodation centres, trained asylum decision-makers and judges, and established legal support for relocated individuals (Sunak, 2024; BBC, 2024).

2. Government Rationale

The UK government's primary stated objective is deterrence. Prime Minister Rishi Sunak has argued that illegal migrants who know they cannot stay in the UK are less likely to attempt the crossing (Sunak, 2024).

Key government arguments include:

Argument	Explanation
Breaking smuggling networks	Criminal gangs profit from irregular crossings, often using unsafe boats and endangering lives (National Crime Agency, 2021; Duggan, 2023)
Reducing deaths at sea	At least 72 people drowned attempting the crossing between 2018 and 2023 (Ministry of Defence, 2024, cited in BBC, 2024)
Protecting asylum system integrity	Approximately 98% of irregular arrivals lack identity documents, complicating processing and removal (Migration Watch UK, 2022)
National security concerns	Some individuals who entered irregularly have later been convicted of serious offences (Home Office, 2022, cited in gov.uk, 2022)

The government has also noted that many asylum seekers travel through France – a safe country – before reaching the UK, which, under existing legal frameworks, may affect their eligibility for asylum (gov.uk, 2024).

3. Implementation Status

As of May 2026, the policy has faced significant legal challenges. The first flight to Rwanda was prevented by the European Court of Human Rights in June 2022. Subsequent legislation (the Safety of Rwanda Act 2024) was passed to address legal obstacles. The first removals occurred in April 2025, but the scale of implementation remains limited compared to initial government targets.

4. Early Results and Deterrence Effects

4.1 Impact on Ireland

Following the policy's announcement, Ireland reported an increase in asylum claims from individuals who had previously been in the UK. In April 2024, Irish Minister Helen McEntee stated that over 80% of recent claims came from people crossing the border from Northern Ireland (BBC, 2024). The Irish government subsequently introduced emergency legislation to return asylum seekers to the UK.

This suggests that the policy has had some deterrent effect, redirecting movement rather than eliminating it entirely.

4.2 Reduction in Crossings

Government data indicates a reduction in irregular crossings following the policy's announcement and implementation. However, disentangling the policy's impact from other factors (e.g., weather conditions, French enforcement efforts, EU agreements) remains methodologically challenging.

5. Criticisms and Concerns

5.1 Human Rights Concerns

Amnesty International and other organisations have argued that the policy is unlawful and risks exposing asylum seekers to harm (Amnesty International, 2024). Specific concerns include:

- Rwanda's human rights record, including restrictions on political opposition and press freedom.
- The risk of refoulement (returning asylum seekers to countries where they face persecution).
- Inadequate legal safeguards for relocated individuals.

5.2 Cost-Effectiveness

The National Audit Office (2024) has questioned the policy's value for money. The UK government has committed substantial funds, while the number of individuals relocated remains very low. Critics argue that the same resources could have been used to process claims more quickly within the UK.

5.3 Limited Implementation

Despite government announcements, the number of individuals actually relocated to Rwanda remains a small fraction of illegal arrivals. Legal challenges and logistical difficulties have significantly delayed implementation.

5.4 Impact on Ireland

While the government presents the movement to Ireland as evidence of deterrence, Irish authorities have criticised the policy for externalising migration pressures onto neighbouring countries (Harris, 2024, cited in BBC, 2024).

6. Policy Implications for Europe

The Rwanda model represents a novel approach to migration deterrence: outsourcing asylum processing to a third country. Several European countries have expressed interest in similar arrangements. However, the policy's legal, financial, and ethical viability remains unproven.

Key questions for European policymakers:

- Are such agreements compatible with the European Convention on Human Rights?
- Do they create perverse incentives, shifting migration pressures rather than reducing them?
- Are there more cost-effective and humane alternatives (e.g., faster processing, expanded legal pathways)?

7. Conclusion

The UK-Rwanda Migration Partnership has introduced a new paradigm in migration deterrence. It has shown some early signs of deterrent effect, including reduced crossings and secondary movement to Ireland. However, significant concerns remain regarding human rights, cost-effectiveness, and legal viability.

The policy's long-term success – defined as a sustained reduction in irregular crossings without causing humanitarian harm – is not yet proven. European policymakers should monitor the scheme closely before adopting similar models.

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